

that does not include and plan for business-facing application workloads will have no returns from business. It may be promptly shelved as yet-another IT operational initiative that can wait for better times or forwarded to business, pending further discussion on a rainy and dull day.

Cloud implementation is not strategy

A cloud strategy document that goes deep into the process of technology, platform and supplier selection is going down the wrong side of the road. An implementation document cannot substitute a strategic document that describes the business goals and the longer-term innovation benefits for the organisation. IT cannot follow a wild west approach, where all pending IT objectives and innovation goals are piggybacked onto the cloud rollout project. This will lead to huge project and architecture overruns, associated with capital debt and return on investment failures.

Internal IT and business audit

Like any IT project initiative, it is necessary to capture the states of the IT and business organisation before and after the start of the rollout. Internal audit should be able to answer the following questions from various end users:

- What benefits are you seeking from the cloud?
- Why is the organisation implementing a cloud framework?
- What are the decision-making criteria for application workloads?
- What is the readiness of the application portfolio?
- As an IT and business end-user, are you ready to use cloud?
- Do you need an external supplier?

Lastly, launch of a successful cloud strategy requires a trusted partner to ensure that vision gets converted into reality. Cloud has various models of consumption and configuration, and this is also

driven by internal requirements and policies. Legacy data needs to be migrated and configured on whichever cloud platform is selected for implementation. Multiple cloud platforms may also need to be introduced into the organisation. Increasingly, cloud brokers and managed service providers are playing an important role, at least in the early and middle stages of a cloud rollout.

By following some of these measures, CIOs may be able to formulate an effective cloud strategy. This will act as a bridge between IT and business, and kick start digital innovation in the organisation. **END** 

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